

Monotremes

The only egg-laying mammals, monotremes include the platypus, which feeds in water, and spiny anteaters, or echidnas, which live on land. Unlike other mammals, female monotremes lack nipples. They ooze milk onto their skin, and their young lap it up.



Echidnas eat insects using their long snouts and sticky tongues. They have powerful legs with huge claws that they use for digging and tearing open logs.

Marsupials

Most marsupials raise their young inside a pouch. Nipples inside the pouch provide the young with milk. Kangaroos and koalas usually give birth to a single offspring. Opossums can give birth to several dozen, although not all survive.



American opossums will eat almost anything, including poisonous snakes. They often live in trees and are agile climbers with scaly, grasping tails and sharp claws.



Young koalas eat their mothers' feces, or pap, which gives them the bacteria they will need to digest eucalyptus leaves, their main food source.

Mammals

Mammals are hairy, warm-blooded animals that feed their young on milk. Except for monotremes, all give birth to live offspring. Marsupials are tiny when they are born, but other mammals often emerge well developed. There are about 5,400 species. They live on land and in water.

Aardvark

This African mammal has no close relatives and is classified on its own. It eats termites and ants, breaking into their nests with its powerful front claws. With keen senses of hearing and smell but poor eyesight, it hides during the day in deep burrows.



The aardvark's protruding snout contains a long, sticky tongue that can reach deep into insect nests.

Sea cows

Unlike seals, sea cows feed entirely on plants. These large, aquatic mammals include the dugong, which lives along shallow tropical coasts, and manatees, which also venture into rivers. All have barrel-shaped bodies and a lobed or paddle-shaped tail.



A manatee's flippers swing forward to hold plants when feeding. Its mouth has a grasping, or prehensile, upper lip.

Elephants

Instantly recognizable by their long trunks, elephants are the biggest land animals. They have pillarlike legs, enormous ears, and long incisor teeth, or tusks. Elephants use their tusks to break open tree trunks and to dig for water and salt.



The African savanna elephant is the largest elephant species. Some males weigh more than 7½ tons (7 metric tons).

Anteaters and relatives

Anteaters, armadillos, and sloths form a single group of related mammals. They look different, but they share telltale features, such as unusual joints in their backbones. Anteaters and armadillos eat small animals, but sloths live in trees and feed on leaves.



Tamanduas are tree-climbing anteaters with grasping tails. They have long tongues but no teeth.